population with its affinities to the Tibetans or Chinese have all the elements of the potential trouble between China and ourselves.' [36]

To some extent, the performance of India in this first important negotiation with China could be put down to a lack of experience in diplomatic negotiations. The Chinese had an advantage. They not only had an unbroken tradition of diplomatic experience because they never fully lost their independence and continued to engage with outside powers, but Mao Zedong and Zhou Enlai had also practiced diplomacy with the Soviets, the Americans and the Japanese through the 1930s and 1940s. India's leadership, on the other hand, had little hands-on knowledge of the conduct of diplomacy, and the problem was compounded because of a faulty strategy that was not anchored in good intelligence about Chinese calculations, and was overdependent on Nehru's personal preferences and intuitions rather than on any consultation. Nonetheless, the way both parties approached the issue contains important lessons.

The Chinese identified clear objectives before the start of the negotiations, publicly spelt them out and built their strategy accordingly. Their leadership maintained close and continuous consultation through the entire process (even when Mao was travelling abroad) and adjusted tactics as required. India neither had concrete objectives nor clear 'asks' from the Chinese side. Strategy was defined not in terms of identified outcomes, but in terms of the international calendar. Tactics were decided accordingly. There is no indication that there was serious political level consultation in the Government of India on this issue. The Prime Minister and the Ministry of External Affairs appeared to decide the policy. India gained little tangible benefit from the entire exercise.